Blumberg and Hawthorne on Want

Cian Dorr | NYU | Mind and Language Seminar, 5th May 2026.

1 'Prefer' ≈ 'want more'

(1) a. I prefer the beach trip to the hiking trip, but I don't want to go on the hiking trip any more than I want to go on the beach trip.
b. I want to go on the hiking trip more than I want to go on the beach trip, but I don't prefer the hiking trip to the beach trip.

- The case is maybe a bit less clear with 'would prefer'. But that can just be attributed to the fact that 'would prefer' also has natural readings that involve a genuine counterfactual element (where we look at what your mental state would be if you got the thing).

2 'Want more' is not downward monotonic in either argument

These sound OK to me, even in the 4-way randomization scenario:

(2) a. I want to get pasta more than I want to get chicken. But I don't want to get spaghetti bolognese more than I want to get chicken.
b. I want to get pasta more than I want to get chicken. But I don't want to get pasta more than I want to get chicken cacciatore.

Also, it's hard to see how 'want more' could be downward monotonic (in an argument) without 'want at least as much' being downward monotonic (in the same argument).

But downward monotonicity for 'want at least as much' in the first argument would have the completely implausible consequence that 'want' is downward monotonic, given the validity of

Comparative Monotonicity

a is F	S wants p.
b is at least as F as a is	S' wants p' at least as much as S wants p.
So, b is F	So, S' wants p'.

(3) S wants p.
S wants p at least as much as S wants p.
So, S wants p^+ at least as much as S wants p.
So, S wants p^+.

3 'Want more' is not upward monotonic in either argument

Obviously not in the second:

(4) I don't want to get pasta more than I want to get chicken, although I do want to get pasta more than I want to get chicken cacciatore.

But also not in the first argument, I think:

(5) a. I want the coin to land heads every time more than I want it to land tails first time. But I don't want it to land heads first time more than I want it to land tails first time.
b. I don't want to get posted to Germany any more than I want to get posted to France, although I do want to get posted to Berlin more than I want to get posted anywhere else.

4 'Want more' is still odd when one argument entails the other

(6) a. ? I want chicken cacciatore more than I want chicken
b. ? I want chicken more than I want chicken cacciatore

But if we reject monotonoicity, we can't say that's because such sentences are always false!

Given that 'want more' is not downward monotonic in the first argument, surely (7a–b) could both be true; but then (6b) is true too, by transitivity:

(7) a. I want chicken more than pasta.
b. I want pasta more than chicken cacciatore.

So there's some other kind of constraint on what sorts of alternatives can felicitously be contrasted.

Obviously the prejacents don't have to be *exclusive*: it's fine to utter

(8) I want Ann to come more than I want Bill to come

even when it's possible that both Ann and Bill will come. The problem seems to only concern *nested* prejacents.

- You could imagine just writing this in as an ad hoc piece of NAI content. But ideally we'd like an explanatory account that could unify this effect with similar phenomena that arise in other domains:

(9) ? We'd have a better time if we went to Berlin than if we went to Germany.

I wonder if this effect—whatever it is—could explain some of the 'bad conjunction' data that B&H use to motivate monotonicity for 'want'?

(10) a. I want the coin to land heads every time, but I don't want it to land Heads first time.

b. I want to be posted to Berlin, but I don't want to be posted to Germany.

These would entail odd 'want more' claims with nested prejacents, given the validity of

Strong Comparative Monotonicity

a is *F*	*S* wants *p*.
b is not *F*	*S*′ doesn't want *p*′.
So, *a* is more *F* than *b*	So *S* wants *p* more than *S*′ wants *p*′.

5 'Want a lot' and 'strongly desire' aren't upward monotonic

You'd expect various degree modifiers to have the same logic as explicit comparisons. And indeed, I don't see strong pressure towards monotonicity for them:

(11) a. I strongly desire the coins to all land heads, but I don't strongly desire the first one to land Heads.

b. I really want to visit Berlin, but I don't particularly want to go to Germany, since I think it's unlikely we'd make it to Berlin.

On a standard view of comparatives, the positive form involves an operator POS which occupies the same semantic slot as 'very' etc. Given that, it would be mysterious if 'want' had a different logical behaviour from 'want a lot'.

6 If 'want more' isn't upward monotonic in the first argument, 'want' isn't upward monotonic

Strong Comparative Monotonicity forces a 'threshold' model. The degrees of desire that make a 'want' attribution true are all above the ones that don't. But if the degree can diminish between something and one of its consequences, it would be quite puzzling if the threshold can never fall between the two!

I guess you could have a lexical model, where the degree to which you want a proposition is a function of (i) the best world/alternative compatible with it, and (ii) its expected value, where (ii) only breaks ties in (i), and the threshold for 'want' only cares about (i). But this seems silly.

7 How does 'want more' behave in special contexts?

Even if we take 'want' not to be upward monotonic, B&H's observations suggest that there are special contexts in which 'Bill wants the first coin to land Heads' is true.

(12) a. He wants all the coins to land heads, so he wants the first coin to land heads

b. He wants the first coin to land heads, though of course only as part of a scenario where all three of them land heads.

A good question: is (13) still true in these special contexts?

(13) He wants the first coin to land Tails more than he wants it to land Heads

A model where it is: 'want more' still tracks expected value in these contexts; it's just that for some reason they have a really low threshold for 'want'.

(14) Given that you want for all of them to land Heads, you must want the first one to land heads at least *a little* bit.

A model where it isn't: in the special contexts, the degree to which you want something equals the degree to which you want the best alternative compatible with it (so 'want more' becomes upward monotonic in the first argument and downward in the second).

Imagine a variant scenario where instead of the first coin toss there is a roll of a die marked 1,1,2,2,3,3:

Die shows 1 → double your fortune if HH; lose everything otherwise
Die shows 2 → break even no matter how the coin lands
Die shows 3 → lose \$1000 no matter how the coin lands

If 'want more' goes by expected utility, you want the die to show 3 more than you want it to show 1. But if we have got ourselves into a context where 'He wants the die to show 1, since he wants to double his fortune' is true, is 'he wants the die to show 3' also true? That does seem weird.